

BEFORE

Even before the Greeks began pursuing geographical knowledge from 600 BCE, some people's experience of travel, trade, and communication was extensive.



BABYLONIAN VIEW OF THE WORLD

MYTHICAL GEOGRAPHY

Early concepts of the shape of the world owe much to myths << 102–03. People had seemingly fantastical concepts of far-off lands. This schematic diagram of the world (left) dating to 1000–500 BCE describes mythical beings inhabiting the corners of the world. The perspective is centered on the city of

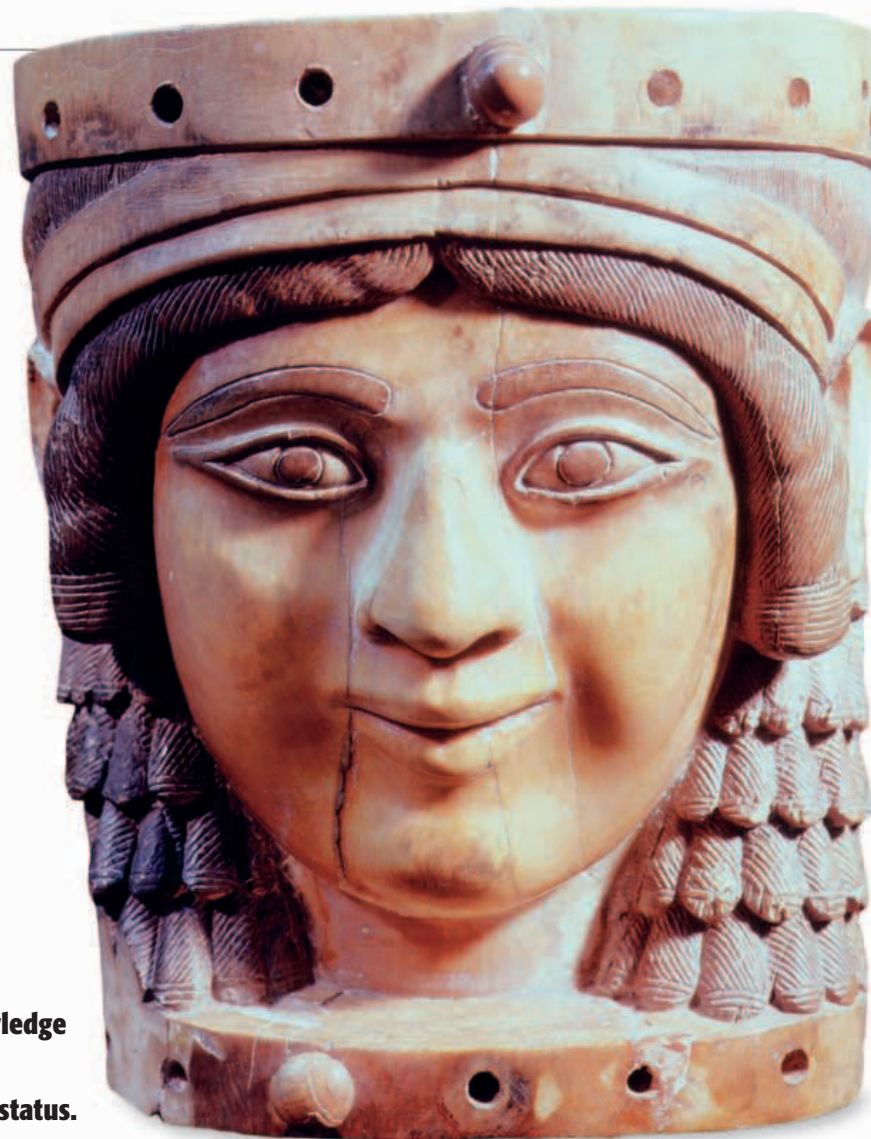
Babylon in Mesopotamia (modern Iraq), and real locations, labeled with their names, surround it in rough correlation to reality. The tablet is a visual concept of the world rather than a guide to it.

DISTANT CONNECTIONS

Although some people traveled far in the ancient world, the knowledge of geography they acquired only gradually came to be expressed as maps or texts. Instead, the powerful showed off their connections with monuments in the landscape, or by displaying possessions from distant lands.

THE WEALTH OF TRADE CITIES

Since Phoenician times << 82–83, cities that could control trade had become wealthy. Some city-states and kingdoms were built on their monopoly on goods such as incense or silk.



A Wider World

Links across the ancient world were forged by merchants, rulers, and migrants. Through increasing cultural exchange, societies gained knowledge of distant lands, and as awareness of the world grew, the far-flung connections of worldly and wealthy people were admired as marks of status.

As empires united vast, multicultural regions (see pp.90–91), enterprising explorers and traders found new routes and access to valuable goods. The most luxurious or prestigious commodities were often those that had traveled the greatest distance. Silk that found its way from China to Rome changed hands many times en route, with each middleman taking his markup.

Ideas, stories, religions, languages, all traveled along the trade routes between the various lands. During the Hellenistic Period (see pp.98–99), Greek was a

common language from Greece to India, and Greek gods, such as Zeus, made appearances as far afield as Bactria (modern Afghanistan). The Greek mythical hero Herakles (Hercules), also recorded in Bactria, appears as a statue over a major trade and military route through the Zagros Mountains of Persia (in present-day Iran, see pp.92–93). But here, his identity is blended with the hero Verethraghna of Persian tradition.

Later, as the spheres of influence of Rome, China, and Parthia expanded and overlapped, cultural interchange

began to occur across the whole of Eurasia, and Buddhism spread from India to China via Parthian travelers on the Silk Road. It was a Parthian nobleman called An Shi Kao who, in 148 BCE, was the first to translate Buddhist texts into Chinese.

Traces of trade

The gradual spread of ideas and culture through trade and migration, although little documented, has left many archaeological traces. Artifacts unearthed far from home, such as African ivory in Assyria (see above), a hoard of Roman coins in India, or a Persian carpet in Siberia, provide clear evidence of long-distance trade. The occasional shipwreck can represent a detailed time capsule of information. Ancient writings also build the picture of trails taken by travelers. Documents

Ivory from Africa

Unearthed in Nineveh, the capital of Assyria in 700 BCE, this carving is of elephant ivory, a material the Assyrians would have had access to through contacts with the Phoenicians. Such an exotic commodity from far-off lands would have conveyed status on its owner.

from the Persian capital Persepolis, for instance, note the rations given to official travelers, and the official stops they made across the empire from Sardis (today in western Turkey) in the west to India in the east. In the commercial world, itineraries were drawn up as guides for merchants. One surviving example, written by a Romanized author from Alexandria in Egypt in the 1st century CE, describes the Red Sea and Indian Ocean. It relates the ports and the goods, such as iron, gold, silver, myrrh, and slaves, available for import and export in each, and extends its account to the



Greek in Central Asia

Common languages spread across vast, multicultural territories. Here, Greek is used on a 150-BCE coin of Afghanistan, unearthed in Turkey.

Roman road atlas

This view of the world, known as the Peutinger Table, is a medieval copy of a Roman original. It records journeys made across the Roman world and beyond before the 4th century CE. Distances are distorted unrecognizably to preserve the order of places and routes in a clear itinerary.



Ganges River and beyond, to China. Such knowledge was consolidated into an accurate geographical picture of the world by Greek and Roman map-makers. In the 2nd century CE, Ptolemy of Alexandria compiled *Geographia*—a